umpires were discussing whether to stop play, but I was desperate to stay out there and was praying that they would continue the match for just another few minutes. They did so and Chaminda Vaas, the left-arm fast-medium bowler, was put on to bowl. Vaas was bowling wide of my off stump with a packed off-side field and I knew I had to try something different. I decided to play a chip shot behind the wicket from way outside off stump, a shot no one would expect me to play just a few runs short of my century. I got it just right and to everyone's surprise reached 97 with a well-calculated risk.

The umpires checked the light again at the end of the over and to my relief decided to carry on. I knew I had at least a few more minutes to get to the hundred. In the next over from Vaas, by which time I had picked up two more singles, I had already made up my mind not to repeat the shot. I predicted that Vaas would be expecting me to paddle-sweep and would change his line and bowl to me on the stumps. I was proved right and he bowled a ball on middle stump which I played towards square leg for a single.

I was so delighted at reaching the century that I did something very out of character. I shouted in jubilation and celebrated in a manner I had hardly ever done in my career. I was very proud of the achievement. We went off shortly afterwards and when I got back to the dressing room I couldn't control my emotions. With tears flowing down my cheeks, I made four phone calls – to Anjali, Ajit, my mother and Achrekar Sir – to thank them for all they had done.

While I managed to play in the Sri Lanka series, followed by three Tests against Pakistan in January 2006 and England in March 2006, Tests in which I didn't do a great deal, I realized that shoulder surgery was unavoidable if I harboured any ambition of going to the West Indies for the Test series in May. I decided not to play in the one-day series against England and went ahead with the operation on 27 March in London.

The shoulder operation

It wasn't quite as straightforward as planned. As normal, I was sedated before being moved to the operating theatre, but for some reason I suddenly woke up on the trolley and asked the nurse if the operation was over. She was shocked to see me awake and told me that it had not even started. There had been some complication with the previous operation